

ers alright, but there are no roads. When Delhi Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit displayed extraordinary courage in introducing the Bus Rapid Transit (BRT) system on her own, without my help, look at the criticism she was subjected to. There are more cars in Delhi than all the cars put together in Kolkata, Mumbai and Chennai. But they still account for less than 10 per cent of the population in Delhi.

So we are trying to encourage metro rail. Apart from the Delhi Metro, we are encouraging the metro in Kolkata, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Bangalore, Chennai, Kochi, wherever the state governments come forward with 50 per cent equity; wherever the state governments come forward for the PPP model, we are more than willing to go for it. We have introduced BRT system in as many as 10 cities, including Pune, Hyderabad, Bhopal. I am glad to tell you, there are chief ministers belonging to various states, no chief minister has complained of discrimination under my mission.

When P. Chidambaram was the finance minister, I sought removal of excise duty for buses. He, however, reduced them from 16 per cent to eight per cent. I asked Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee to reduce them further to zero per cent. That is the way to go—strike a big deal for public transportation. Urban subject is the least studied subject. We have no experts. As a consequence, retired engineers and retired urban development officials are the best experts we are left with. We need to go in for capacity building. We are thinking, we are providing money for building 13 centres of excellence on urban studies—on metro transport, be it rail or bus, on various IITs and IIMs. We need 13 centres of excellence because no centre of excellence on urban studies can survive on its own. It is only on a big campus, like that of IIT or IIM, can they flourish?

Now, what do we do with slums? Friends, a new solution emerged. The slums were occupied by people who really are construction workers. We need to remember that the buildings where we live were all built by people living in slums. Some of us may have some ignorant and concealed contempt for these people. These people built our houses, our colonies but their lands have become very precious. Therefore, we can use their lands and let them live in



SHEILA DIKSHIT
Chief Minister, Delhi

I don't know how will we be able to cater to the growing population if we are going to get an influx of people—five lakh coming in Delhi every year and a million coming in to work daily from surrounding areas. The city's services are also getting stressed out. Now, how are we going to manage a city the size of Delhi? Are we going to look for a solution or not? It has been projected that between the years 2020-25, fifty per cent of India's population would be living in cities. But will they live only in Delhi, Kolkata, Mumbai and Chennai or are we going to build other cities as well?



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multi-storied structures—what we call in-situation development or in-situ development. In Delhi, we are going in for 6,50,000 houses through the DDA and other organisations through in-situ development and we are prepared to look at various proposals.

The states need to take a close look and spare more money for orderly urban development. They need to see that our urban local bodies tax the rich and not just the poor. The problem with our municipal bodies is that the poor are poor and therefore they can't be taxed. You can't tax the rich because they are influential and you have to see the kind of bankruptcy the municipal bodies face to believe it. We need to see that the capacity building in municipal bodies takes place and we also need to see that their financial strength goes up.

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